This hearty Italian country soup has deep, earthy flavors. Check the mushrooms after soaking, because there may be bits of dirt or straw that need to be removed.

porcini mushroom soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS, PLUS 30 MINS STANDING **COOK** 1 HR **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE BREAD

1oz (30g) dried porcini mushrooms
3 tbsp extra virgin olive oil, plus extra to serve
2 onions, finely chopped
2 tsp chopped fresh rosemary leaves
1 tsp fresh thyme leaves
2 garlic cloves, finely sliced
4oz (115g) chestnut mushrooms, sliced
2 celery ribs with leaves, finely chopped
1 x 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
3¼ cups vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
½ stale ciabatta or small crusty white loaf, torn into chunks

1 Put the dried porcini in a heatproof bowl, pour over 1¼ cups boiling water, and let stand for 30 minutes. Drain, reserving the soaking liquid, then chop any large pieces of porcini.

2 Heat the oil in a saucepan, add the onions, cover, and let cook for 10 minutes, or until soft. Add the rosemary, thyme, garlic, chestnut mushrooms, and celery, and continue cooking, uncovered, until the celery has softened.

3 Add the tomatoes, porcini, and the stock. Strain the soaking liquid through a piece of muslin or a fine sieve into the pan. Bring the soup to a boil, then lower the heat and simmer gently for 45 minutes.

4 Season to taste with salt and pepper, and add the chunks of bread. Remove the pan from the heat. Cover and let stand for 10 minutes before serving. Spoon into deep bowls and drizzle each serving with a little olive oil.